

**EVALUATE THE EXTENT TO WHICH
SMALL STATES CAN INFLUENCE
INTERNATIONAL SECURITY
OUTCOMES THROUGH MILITARY
AND NON-MILITARY MEANS**

Lilliputians Leveraging Legitimacy

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1 Introduction

1.1 Introduction

This chapter introduces the debate regarding small state influence. It defines influence, legitimacy and what it means to be a small state. The essay employs a four-effects framework scaffold throughout, comprising niche specialisation and soft power, organisational agility, hybrid leverage and legitimacy. This framework is intended to act as a pathway for the argument. This essay's hypothesis is that: small states are limited in their ability to dictate outcomes, but may still shape them conditionally through legitimacy and institutional engagement. This is explained by multilateral organisations narrowing power gaps, lowering the costs of diplomacy and imposing limits on big states (Steinsson and Thorhallsson 2017; Katzenstein 1985).

1.2 Defining the Small State

Material definitions stress GDP, population, territory and force projection (Keohane 1969; Biddle 1996; Crowards 2002; Brooks and Stanley 2007; Beckley 2018). On this view Ireland, Denmark and Qatar are small. Wolf (2016) adds structural resource scarcity. Perceptual lenses judge smallness by position and vulnerability. Campbell and Hall (2017) focuses on vulnerability, Thorhallsson (2006) offers six metrics, Browning (2006) and Vitaliev (2019) treat smallness as socially constructed (Finland and Russia) and Jugl (2020) separates absolute from relative measures.

Paterson (1969) and Vital (1967) flag market and supply exposure where great powers enjoy informational advantages. Hence a small power often struggles to gather and process information. By contrast, Katzenstein (1985)¹ shows post-1945 power accruing through economic alignment, with democratic corporatism sustaining external legitimacy. Dense networks can offset scale disadvantages, per Jugl (2020). Yet information alone

¹His 1985 book has been highly commended, such as by Atkinson (1986).

does not ensure judgement (Paterson 1969). Terrain, domestic cohesion, partners and alternative markets can outweigh size. This aligns with Keohane (without determinism) since policy-maker agency persists (Bessner and Guilhot 2015; Waltz 1979; Morgenthau 1946). Browning (2006) believes that the, “framework of big-small is increasingly less relevant”.

These perspectives refine this essay’s hypothesis. Small states retain agency to act, yet boundaries are imposed by external structure and perception. The English-language literature privileges Western and Cold War cases. Hence post-colonial and digital-era small states remain under-explored.

This essay therefore defines a small state as one that lacks the material or diplomatic means to act unilaterally and must instead pursue influence through adaptation, perception and legitimacy, within systems dominated by larger powers. Ireland’s small state posture is contingent upon and adaptive to, international structures.

1.3 Defining Influence

For this essay, influence is the deliberate shaping of actors’ perceptions, decisions and behaviour to achieve political objectives. It operates by targeting knowledge, beliefs and emotions through information activities (Kuijt, Keja, and Slaager 2023). The military instrument is employed to coerce, deter or reassure, as context demands (UK Ministry of Defence 2023). Influence is often leveraged in the grey zone. Information operations, economic pressure and cyber activity seek outcomes without escalation (Atlantic Council, Forward Defense Experts 2022). For assessment purposes, small state influence is observed as shifts in mandates, allocations, coalition behaviour and delivery priorities, rather than control.

1.4 Defining Legitimacy

Legitimacy denotes the perception that a state’s conduct is appropriate, credible and aligned with accepted norms and institutions (Clark 2005), leveraging soft power (Nye 2008). It varies between rational co-operative and normative forms (Keohane 1988). Mil-

itary means are usually marginal for small states. However, legitimacy allows them to frame actions as norm consistent. Ireland’s United Nations (UN) peacekeeping has gained disproportionate recognition despite material limits, per Rothstein (1966). Institutional performance, not myth, generates legitimacy. Estonia’s post-2007 coordination built trust at home and credibility abroad (Crandall and Allan 2015). Austria shows similar EU-anchored effects (Gebhard 2013).

Legitimacy works externally by amplifying voice. It works internally by sustaining consent and is fragile (Bailes, Thorhallsson, and Johnstone 2013). United Nations Security Council (UNSC) paralysis during the 2023–2025 Israel–Gaza War reduced the stage for small state voice (Rakipoğlu and Duman 2025). Decisive actions came via US diplomacy for a “Middle East Peace Plan”. Indeed, Ireland’s absence from the signing ceremony signalled weak perceived legitimacy with Washington. The Liberal International Order (LIO) shows strain rather than collapse (Lake, Martin, and Risse 2021; Sanaei 2024). Overall, legitimacy should be analysed as a conditional influence, which must be carefully and actively cultivated.

1.5 Methodology

This essay adopts a *structured-focused comparison* (George and Bennett 2005) and an author-devised four-effects framework to evaluate small state influence. Cases comprise Ireland, Estonia, Israel and the DPRK. They are selected for *theoretical relevance* to Ireland’s neutral, EU-aligned posture and to test the framework.

Sources combine *peer-reviewed IR theory*, *Irish policy documents* and *contemporary literature* to balance academic rigour with policy salience. Scope is delimited to contemporary Europe and UN/EU frameworks. It excludes Asia-Pacific and pre-2000 cases.

Case selection risks bias towards visible actors. Less successful small states are omitted. The framework may overstate coherence in state behaviour. Irish sources dominate, reflecting author positionality within the Army. These constraints are mitigated through counterfactual testing in Chapter 3 and realist stress-testing across cases.

1 Introduction

This design directly supports the module outcomes. It applies strategic theory to small-state security and situating Ireland in comparative context.

1.5.1 The Four-Effects Framework

To structure the analysis, the essay applies four effects. First, *niche specialisation and soft power* locates contributory strengths (e.g., diplomacy, peacekeeping, cyber, mediation). Second, *organisational agility* pertains to faster coordination relative to larger powers. Third, *hybrid leverage* exploits interdependence and regulatory niches (Keohane 1969; Bailes, Thorhallsson, and Johnstone 2013). Fourth, *legitimacy* sustains all three. The framework tests positive and critical cases, links theory to Ireland and provides continuity across chapters. Chapter 2 applies it to supportive evidence. Chapter 3 examines weaknesses or failures. Chapter 4 compares cases. As an author-devised tool, it risks overstating coherence. It is therefore applied critically to highlight fragility, as well as promise.

1.6 Summary

This chapter has defined the small state category and influence. It has indicated legitimacy to be the Centre of Gravity (COG) for small states. It outlined the four-effects framework to be applied throughout the essay. The next chapter examines the reasons supporting the hypothesis and shows how small states generate conditional influence.

2 Reasons for the Proposal

This chapter applies the four-effects framework positively to show how small states can exercise conditional influence in international security. The purpose is to demonstrate that under specific conditions, small states can influence security debates and outcomes asymmetrically.

2.1 Niche Specialisation and Soft Power

Within the English School's solidarist view of international society, small states are likely to gain influence by specialising in roles that embody shared norms and values (Linklater and Suganami 2006, pp. 108–113) and (Friedner Parrat 2024, pp. 451–454) and (Tonra 1999, p. 152). Quinn (2018, p. 93) and Rothstein (1966) show that Ireland's peacekeeping niche projects legitimacy through impartial UN engagement. It has earned disproportionate respect from the limited means committed. This professionalism constitutes a form of normative power, per Nye (2008, p. 96), who defines soft power as attraction grounded in values and legitimacy. Keohane (1969) suggests that some states are "system-influencing", as they achieve asymmetric influence. Small states can leverage niche specialisation and soft power for influence, improving credibility and normative appeal (Long 2017; Sanaei 2024). Flynn (2019) advocates for niche specialisation. In Krepinevich's (1994) words, it allows small states to "steal a march" on larger powers.

Ireland's UN peacekeeping missions and Estonia's cyber actions demonstrate how specialisation generates visibility and influence (Minihan 2018, pp. 143–145) (Flynn 2019). These align with solidarist ideals to promote human rights and welfare (Linklater and Suganami 2006, pp. 242–246). This specialisation links with soft power synergy, where cultural values and norms enhance attraction and legitimacy (Nye 2008). For example, through mediation or neutrality. Other states may "want to follow", gaining international support and shaping norms without coercion (Nye 2008; Villa and Jenne 2020) and (Linklater and Suganami 2006, p. 135). Legitimacy can convert niche expertise and soft

power into outcomes, but only when functioning institutions use those strengths (Clark 2005, p. 245) and (Crandall and Allan 2015).

2.2 Organisational Agility

Small states gain influence when they design bureaucracies which are more agile than those burdened by entrenched routines. “Bureaucratic inertia” frustrates innovation in large organisations Krepinevich (2002, p. 34). Since bureaucracies are the principal link between state and society (Katzenstein 1976, pp. 13–19), their structure sets the pace of policy and the credibility of external commitments. Though small states cannot unilaterally dictate outcomes, they can influence (Keohane 1969).

Agility is the practical route to that status. Cohesive networks and shorter attention chains converts social proximity into administrative effectiveness (Jugl 2020, pp. 98–100). Ireland’s recent reform agenda underscores the point. Reorganising command relationships, professionalising personnel systems and strengthening joint processes is an attempt at agility (Department of Defence and Defence Forces 2022). Agility compounds when linked to the right venues. Crandall and Allan (2015) shows how Estonia paired rapid domestic cyber capacity with NATO, to shape doctrine after 2007. This translated a nimble organisation into rule-shaping influence despite limited mass. When small states hard-wire speed and coordination at home and channel them through multilateral institutions, organisational agility becomes a repeatable path to influence.

2.3 Legitimacy

Legitimacy serves as the COG for small states’ influence on international security outcomes. It rests on the belief that conduct is rightful and credible, not on fixed moral law (Clark 2005, pp. 245–246). After 1945, expanded institutional membership raised smaller states’ standing when they aligned practice with shared rules (Clark 2005, pp. 245–256). Crandall and Allan (2015) argues that multilateral institutions level the playing field with great powers. In English School terms, solidarist commitments can translate credibility into voice (Linklater and Suganami 2006, pp. 108–113). Shelter with credible partners

reinforces legitimacy signals by coupling small state reputations to reliable frameworks (Bailes and Thorhallsson 2013). Institutions then amplify small state voice as ‘system-affecting’ actors, when they can mobilise collective procedures and rules (Keohane 1969, p. 295). Ireland’s UN peacekeeping niche shows how neutrality projects ethical credibility, which earns diplomatic respect (Quinn 2018; Minihan 2018; Flynn 2019; Tonra 1999). The International Criminal Court is a notable example, where legitimacy is perceived while most of the world’s population live in states who don’t recognise it.

Given her victory in the 2025 Irish presidential election, TD Catherine Connolly’s statements merit scrutiny, since they may be emblematic of the society. Ireland must, “speak truth to power and we can only do that if we maintain our credibility” (Virgin Media News 2025, 6:08–6:12).

Legitimacy is fragile and erodes when action does not follow rhetoric or when institutional backing weakens. Small states must sustain credibility through normative behaviour to shape security outcomes effectively.

2.4 Hybrid Leverage

Hybrid leverage enables small states to turn niche capability into rule-shaping power. This requires coupling it to platforms where rules, resources and reputations intersect. First, technical specialisation is converted into agenda influence. When a small state develops recognised expertise (cyber, finance, standards), alliances and institutions amplify that voice. This lets the specialist draft concepts, host exercises and steer doctrine (Crandall and Allan 2015). Second, a state’s ‘nodal’ position can amplify influence. While global interdependence favours powerful states, shared rules and procedures give smaller states leverage (Slaughter 2017, pp. 159–201). By working through committees, shared regulations and coalitions, small states can make larger powers follow their standards and rules (Farrell and Newman 2019). By leading through procedures and building a trusted reputation, they turn limited power into real influence (Bjøl 1968). Ireland’s position as a tech hub illustrates this point through General Data Protection Regulation (GDPR). Its hosting of global tech firms makes Ireland a lead EU authority for major GDPR cases.

Leverage lasts when several advantages align such as allies, location, legal protection and political will because it's harder for great powers to ignore small states (Paterson 1969).

2.5 Summary

Having established the positive mechanisms through which small states can exert influence, this essay now tests their limits. The next chapter uses the same four-effects framework under realist limits. It tests outcomes when niches lose meaning, agility slows, hybrid leverage creates dependence, soft power weakens and legitimacy is withdrawn. The aim is to balance the demonstrated potential with the structural realities which may undermine small state influence.

3 Reasons Against the Proposal

This chapter applies the four-effects framework to test the limits of small-state influence. Niche specialisation can slip into tokenism, organisational agility is constrained and hybrid leverage can provoke escalation. Realists such as Waltz, Mearsheimer and Gray argue small states remain structurally marginal. Evidence shows that apparent influence can collapse into symbolism, dependency or irrelevance.

3.1 Niche Specialisation and Soft Power Under Strain - Analysed via Ireland's Peacekeeping

Niche specialisation can amplify small-state influence, but only when capability meets a credibility threshold and the validating institution is effective. Hellmüller, Tan, and Bara (2024) show that peacekeeping is in structural decline as Security Council paralysis and fiscal constraint narrow mandates and reduce effectiveness. Rakipoğlu and Duman (2025) highlight how persistent UNSC paralysis during recent conflicts has hollowed the multilateral stage on which small states once built legitimacy. Yet Lake, Martin, and Risse (2021) argue that while the liberal order is strained it has not collapsed.

Cottey (2022) argues Ireland's UN-based legitimacy is increasingly untenable, given declining missions and domestic under-investment. By contrast, comparable nations field major platforms, such as strategic lift aircraft (Austria) and multi-role vessels (New Zealand) (Flynn 2019). The Commission on the Defence Forces (2022) and Department of Defence and Defence Forces (2025) and Government of Ireland (2019, p. 44) link legitimacy to visible domestic commitments. These include maritime patrolling, cyber defence and credible resourcing.

Legitimacy remains possible, but only by adapting to functioning institutions. Ireland's long-standing peacekeeping niche described by Tonra (1999) thus yields diminishing returns as the UN's credibility erodes — theorised by Friedner Parrat (2024, pp. 451–456).

Alternative legitimacy can be cultivated through credible coalition roles within functioning frameworks. The decline of UN peacekeeping indicates a sunset for niches.

Israel demonstrates how small states can defy the niche logic by pursuing coercive strategies under great power shelter. Its nuclear deterrent and US backing enable influence which no niche contribution could provide. This underlines Waltz (1979)'s neorealist point. Structure and material power ultimately determine outcomes. The decline of peacekeeping does not imply futility of niches. Hence, small states must innovate new niches rather than relying on those tied to declining institutions.

3.2 The Limits of Organisational Agility

Organisational agility is blunted by fiscal and bureaucratic centralisation, path dependence and procurement inertia. These factors severely limit their agency to influence international security outcomes through non-military means.

Mearsheimer's (1994; 2019) offensive realism contends that even adaptive reforms cannot overcome the pressures of great power competition. While small states may adapt internally, the strategic environment is set by large actors. Agility matters only when it generates political consequences (Gray 2018; Gray 2005). Cohen (2002) notes that without a productive "unequal dialogue" between policy-makers and practitioners¹ change reduces to a mere procedural formality.

Small states often build larger public sectors to protect against external risk (Cameron 1978; Alesina and Wacziarg 1997; Rodrik 1998). Katzenstein (1985, p. 47) deems this to be 'domestic compensation'. It is a welfare centralisation which hardens states. State traditions can filter politically-adopted reforms and dilute their effect (Peters 1997, pp. 77–78). Christensen and Lægreid (1999, pp. 170–180) find that reform is slow because civil-service change is *advisory rather than directive*. Multilateral engagement can further reduce autonomy by socialising administrations and reinforcing inertia (Tonra 1999; Tonra and Christiansen 2011; European Union 2016; European External Action Service 2017; European External Action Service 2018; European External Action Service 2019). Tonra

¹Such as is evident in Norway (Christensen and Lægreid 1999, p. 170).

(1999) records that the EU system has constrained Irish policy options and weakened an independent foreign-policy voice.

Structural factors further reduce the room for agility. ‘Hub’ states can weaponise interdependence through chokepoint effects. They can use control of information and financial networks such as Society for Worldwide Interbank Financial Telecommunication (SWIFT) to coerce others (Farrell and Newman 2019; Sanaei 2024). Small states cannot escape this simply by being agile. This is because institutions mirror power rather than transform it (Mearsheimer 1994; Mearsheimer 2019; Friedner Parrat 2024).

On the military side, elongated procurement cycles magnify inertia. In Ireland this is visible in the slow pace of reform identified by the (Department of Defence and Defence Forces 2022; Commission on the Defence Forces 2022). Such delays limit the ability to project influence even through peacekeeping. Indeed, technological progress is usually realised by conceptual reform (Krepinevich 1994), further slowing the pace of reform. Cognitive and discursive constraints compound these problems. Leaders can overreach under myth-based perceptions of size (Putin’s Russia), while hegemonic narratives can co-opt “responsible” reform (possibly Trump’s USA) (Thorhallsson 2006; Bessner and Guilhot 2015; Sanaei 2024).

Organisational reform can improve efficiency but cannot overcome structural dependence or alliance constraints. Ireland should pursue agility through coalition frameworks and institutional credibility. Internal reform alone cannot yield strategic influence.

3.3 Legitimacy under Pressure

Legitimacy, often posited as the COG for small states, is vulnerable to realist actions by great powers (Clark 2005, p. 245) and (Sanaei 2024). It depends on shared belief within a functioning rules-based order rather than on fixed moral law. When that belief fractures, legitimacy becomes selective and policed by great powers. Linklater and Suganami (2006, pp. 108–113) show that the English School divides legitimacy between pluralist societies (which prioritise order) and solidarist societies (which pursue justice). In the former, small states gain legitimacy by rule-following, yet struggle to convert it into influence. In the

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latter, moral legitimacy claims collapse when justice is applied selectively or rejected by powerful actors. The Israel–Gaza War illustrates this fragility, as liberal norms clashed with the sovereigntist actions of the United States and Israel. For the English School, legitimacy reflects contingent consensus rather than objective moral law (Linklater and Suganami 2006, p. 111) and (Friedner Parrat 2024).

Ayiotis (2023) shows that Irish neutrality was pragmatic hedging rather than principle, revealing how legitimacy narratives mask structural constraint. Bessner and Guilhot (2015) argue that legitimacy is externally shaped within realist structures. Rakipoğlu and Duman (2025) and Hellmüller, Tan, and Bara (2024) add that UNSC paralysis and peace-keeping decline, hollow the platforms that once amplified small state credibility. Chronic under-investment further weakens legitimacy performance (Cottey 2022; Commission on the Defence Forces 2022).

For small states such as Ireland, legitimacy sustains influence only when recognised by stronger actors and rooted in functioning institutions. Where a state’s capacity for action falls short of its rhetoric, or it relies on the wrong institution, legitimacy becomes performance (Farrell and Newman 2019). As UN authority wanes and EU and NATO frameworks grow stronger, Ireland risks losing the platform that once validated its neutrality (Houses of the Oireachtas 2025). Institutions can still confer legitimacy when they are active and trusted. The remedy is credible delivery within active EU and regional frameworks.

Returning to Connolly, she prioritises a UN-first neutrality and “speaking truth to power”, arguing there is “nothing to be gained by joining big powers” (Virgin Media News 2025, 4:45–6:12). Yet her opposition to the Nice, Lisbon and Fiscal treaties signals resistance to the regional institutional alignment, through which solidarist cooperation is usually made effective (Leahy 2025a). Indeed, recent UNSC paralysis makes such views increasingly performative rather than effective .

3.4 Hybrid Leverage - Analysed Via Estonian Cyber Defence

Hybrid leverage promises influence for small states but often delivers exposure. Tonra (2025) cautions that the USA sees European regulation (such as GDPR) as a threat². Farrell and Newman (2019) show that interdependence empowers hub states, not peripheries, allowing coercion through financial and information chokepoints. Betts (1996) warns that technological dependence creates vulnerabilities greater than any advantage. Crandall and Allan (2015) finds that Estonia's cyber success relied on aligning partner engagement with domestic capacity. Few states can sustain this. Hybrid leverage is threat specific. External challenges invite international coordination, but identity threats demand internal cohesion. Estonia's restrictive citizenship policy limited Russian influence yet caused unrest, proving that hybrid strategies can trade external security for domestic fragility.

Jugl (2020) and Gebhard (2013) argue that credibility depends on institutional performance and coalition support, not just access. Tonra (1999) and Thorhallsson (2006) show that EU socialisation constrains autonomy while providing legitimacy. Waltz (1979) and Mearsheimer (2019) confirm that structural hierarchy limits small state agency. Morgenthau (2006) adds that large states expand to guarantee their own security, leaving small states reactive. Estonia's approach cannot be easily copied by others. Hybrid leverage increases visibility and dependence more than it increases influence. Small states should use hybrid leverage only within credible coalitions supported by domestic resilience and alliance 'shelter'.

3.5 Summary

The previous chapter tested each effect against structural and institutional limits. It showed where niches become token, agility slows, hybrid leverage increases exposure, soft power weakens and legitimacy turns selective. The discussion now treats these limits as conditions not failures. Small states cannot decide outcomes but can shape them

²For instance, Power (2025) records Meta's rejection of the existing rules; described as "completely out of control".

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through legitimacy, institutions and focused coalition roles. The next task is to define these conditions and show how Ireland can turn performance and partnership into influence.

4 Discussion

4.1 Myths, History and Strategic Identity

National myths and history shape small states' strategies. Ireland's wartime neutrality under Éamon de Valera's has been mythologised as a moral stand. Fanning (2015) shows that neutrality was framed as independence from Britain — concealing material weakness. Ayiotis (2023) demonstrates that Irish neutrality evolved through phases of necessity, expediency and convenience. Fleming (2015) argues that post-war policy essentially was 'hedging'. It sought to balance neutrality with selective UN engagement.

These interpretations highlight that neutrality, often presented as principled, was in fact a realist adaptation to internal and external survival pressures. Mythologised narratives, have created a strategic culture which endures. Neutrality has become part of Irish self-understanding. It is perceived to sustain legitimacy abroad and reinforce domestic support for limited defence spending. The Irish Proclamation of Independence is clearly a liberal piece¹. This illustrates how myths and history can cement strategies which may be at odds with structural realities. Historical interpretations risk imposing coherence on inconsistent choices. Policymakers must distinguish myth from structural necessity when drawing on history for guidance.

4.2 Problem Cases

Ireland and Israel test the small state category. Ireland masks realist hedging behind the rhetoric of neutrality, as Ayiotis (2023) shows during *The Emergency*. Israel blends small size with coercive deterrence and shelter (Hirst 2010). These cases demonstrate that 'smallness' is not uniform. Ireland's legitimacy rests on institutions. Israel's influence comes from coercive capacity sheltered by a patron.

¹For example, the reference to "by gallant allies" indicates allyship. "[...] supported by her exiled children in America and by gallant allies in Europe, but relying in the first on her own strength" (Government of Ireland 1916; National Museum of Ireland 1916).

The Democratic People's Republic of Korea (DPRK) is another problem case. While UNSCR 1718 compounds isolationism, possession of nuclear weapons changes the calculus. Its militarised economy leverages the Russo–Ukrainian war for influence.

4.2.1 'Performative Liberalism' in Irish Strategy

The 1916 Proclamation fused liberal ideals with realist necessity. It invoked universal rights and equality to claim moral legitimacy, while mobilising organised force to secure sovereignty (Government of Ireland 1916). This dual logic persisted under de Valera. His policy of neutrality during the Second World War masked quiet and significant cooperation with Britain. It was a pragmatic balance between principle and survival². Ireland's realist strategic-foundations have faded from public memory. What remains is a liberal electorate equating moral stance with legitimacy³. This condition, herein described as *performative liberalism*, sees leaders who sincerely believe in liberal values yet must hedge or act within realist constraints, imposed by dependence on external shelters. The pattern endures through Ireland's unequivocal condemnation of Israel's conduct in Gaza. This is morally consistent but strategically risky. It tests the limits of Irish small state legitimacy (Collins 2025). It reveals how a value-driven foreign policy can collide with reliance on the United States for economic and security shelter, per Tonra (2025). Indeed, beneath performative liberalism, the 12.5% corporate tax rate is the hedge that keeps the shelter intact.

If Connolly's comments are emblematic, they illustrate performative liberalism. This essay considers that her critiques of NATO and purported EU militarisation (Gallagher 2025) demonstrate Irish naïveté. The likely requirement for external military assistance during the 2026 EU Presidency underscores the point (Leahy 2025c)⁴. Ireland thus shows how small state legitimacy can be sustained through moral expression, while survival still depends on the quiet logic of realism.

²Interestingly, de Valera was promised a 32 county Ireland should he enter the war on the Allied side. Given his primary concern was to retain independence, this consideration was ruled out of hand (Fanning 2015).

³It is illustrated through myriad Dáil debates, such as McDonald's comments during Dáil Éireann (2004).

⁴Indeed Wall, Gallagher, and Power (2025) report that, "Ireland is considering asking larger EU nations for security assistance". This would constitute 'performative neutrality', whereby Ireland refuses to provide lethal military aid — but will accept it.

4.3 Ireland, Gaza and the Limits of Small State Influence

Ireland's stance on Gaza elucidates tension. Small states mobilise legitimacy; great powers set outcomes. Politically and socially, Ireland adopted an overt moral position. It used parliamentary diplomacy and coalition-building to influence partners (Hosford 2025; Dáil Éireann 2025a; Dáil Éireann 2025b). These efforts contributed to elements of international consensus. As lamented by Connolly⁵ (Virgin Media News 2025), decisive moves were executed by a superpower. The Middle East Peace Plan is widely attributed to US diplomacy (Ní Aodha 2025). The case illustrates both the promise and limits of influence. Ireland's interventions likely shifted marginal preferences but were not decisive. Moreover, the costs may be non-trivial. Moral positioning jars with economic relationships (notably American) and risks narrowing future room for manoeuvre.

Influence is not intended to be self-destructive, yet in practice there can be trade-offs between principled signalling and strategic resilience. This can be illustrated through the Israeli Settlements in the Occupied Palestinian Territory (Prohibition of Importation of Goods) Bill (OTB) (Houses of the Oireachtas 2025; Joint Committee on Foreign Affairs and Trade 2025). Leahy (2025b) judges it unlikely to have material effect. This essay concurs with Mulhall (2025) and Halem (2025). The OTB will affect US companies which are "central to our economy". Ireland's leaders should reflect upon de Valera's realist diplomacy. Across Gaza and Ukraine, capacity bounds legitimacy's reach, per Jugl (2020). Moral stands can erode economic shelter — relevant should multipolarity return (Friedner Parrat 2024; Sanaei 2024; Halem 2025).

4.4 Legitimacy as Conditional Practice

Past sceptics bracketed legitimacy as inoperative within a realist system (Clark 2005, p. 11), yet its post-war revival created institutions where rightful conduct was recognised and rewarded (Clark 2005, pp. 245–256). Brown (2002, pp. 27–40)'s account of the LIO adds nuance. Rules lack sovereign coercion, while usually treated as law. This enables small

⁵"Can you imagine we're dependent on Trump for a peace initiative between Russia and the Ukraine, the man that's totally behind Israel in a genocide" (Virgin Media News 2025, 15:43–15:53).

states to convert normative arguments into institutional effects. The same reading cautions against overreach. Opposition can thin legitimacy. Nowadays, revisionist challenges and transactional great power politics make these reductions more frequent (Villa and Jenne 2020; Friedner Parrat 2024; Sanaei 2024; Halem 2025). They matter most for small states which depend on rules, procedures and coalitions for influence.

4.5 Applying the Four Effects

The four-effects framework indicates where small states can still gain traction. *Niche specialisation* opens doors when performance crosses credibility thresholds and when venues are operational (Tonra 1999; Quinn 2018; Minihan 2018; Crandall and Allan 2015; Flynn 2019). Ireland's peacekeeping has generated access to solidarist stages. Estonia's cyber niche shows how expertise can be translated into alliance doctrine and practice. *Organisational agility* matters when faster sensing and coordination connect to forums that reward speed with positions, drafting roles or mandate influence. Without political consequences, agility is process rather than power (Jugl 2020; Cohen 2002; Katzenstein 1985; Gray 2005; Gray 2018). *Hybrid leverage* is potent but difficult to reify. Small states need coalitions which can absorb retaliation. Absent shelter, visibility becomes exposure (Thorhallsson 2006; Tonra 1999; Gebhard 2013; Crandall and Allan 2015; Farrell and Newman 2019; Halem 2025). Finally, *legitimacy* remains a conditional COG. Numbers and coalitions can magnify states' voices, but recognition is selective and reversible. Superpowers can override procedurally-sound claims (Clark 2005; Linklater and Suganami 2006; Long 2017).

4.6 What the Gaza and Ukraine Cases Elucidate for

Ireland

The Israel–Gaza episode crystallises the framework's conditions for Ireland. The state used humanitarian diplomacy, mobilised domestic consensus and worked institutional channels. Yet outcomes were set by a superpower. Moral entrepreneurship carries eco-

conomic and diplomatic opportunity costs. After the Russo–Ukrainian War began, Ireland reaffirmed military neutrality while declaring political alignment with the EU. Some Eastern partners viewed this stance negatively, reducing Ireland’s influence within the Union (Fitzgerald 2025). Internally, polarisation risks reducing policy agility (Tonra 2025). Abroad, partners may recalibrate their expectations of Ireland’s role if signalling is performative (Halem 2025). Lilliputians should lead where performance can be converted into text, mandate language or practical delivery.

4.7 Synthesis and Policy Implications

Boundary cases reinforce the conditionality claim. Israel, through shelter and superior capabilities, illustrates how coercion substitutes for legitimacy. The DPRK is shielded by deterrence. It achieves security outcomes despite contested legitimacy. It trades institutional influence for coercive autonomy, per (Waltz 1979; Mearsheimer 2019). For small states, the durable gains lie in the steady conversion of niche performance into institutional outcomes. Leverage institutions with ‘penholderships’, pursue oversight and contact-group roles and align coalition shelter, before attempting norm diffusion. Gaza foregrounds how agency is conditional and cumulative. The reliable path is performance-backed legitimacy — *sine qua non*⁶ — exercised under sufficient ‘shelter’ to keep doors open when great powers set terms.

The evolution of the LIO towards multipolarity counsels Irish caution. Military legitimacy is regaining salience. Ireland’s increasingly pilloried as a defence free-rider (Collins 2025). Its rhetoric has been criticised as sanctimonious, which can reduce influence (McRedmond 2025; Halem 2025). Wise elites should recall the 1916 Proclamation’s injunction to, “rely [...] in the first on her own strength” while being “supported [...] by gallant allies” (Government of Ireland 1916; National Museum of Ireland 1916).

⁶The indispensable condition.

4.8 Central Hypothesis and Performative Liberalism

We return to the essay's hypothesis. This essay identifies a recurrent pattern, whereby Ireland deploys solidarist rhetoric to accrue legitimacy, while structural restrictions force hedging in practice. It predicts a divergence between moral signalling and delivery.

Proposition 1. The signalling-delivery gap widens through institutional paralysis.

Proposition 2. Costs rise when signalling jeopardises shelter.

Falsifier 1. *Cost-free radical signalling.* Advancing solidarist initiatives without measurable diplomatic/economic pushback.

Falsifier 2. *Capacity-free success.* Securing contested penholdership/mandates without prior niche delivery or coalition shelter.

Falsifier 3. *Capacity-free security effects.* Sustaining subsea-infrastructure protection *without* adding national capacity or public acknowledgment, per (Gallagher 2025).

Inference. Ireland exhibits the predicted signalling-to-delivery gap. Estonia and Israel do not.

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Influence is maximised when legitimacy and targeted capacity act in concert (Crandall and Allan 2015). This essay has assessed how small states can influence international security outcomes. It found that agency is real, though conditional. A four-effects framework was used (niche specialisation and soft power, organisational agility, hybrid leverage and legitimacy). It showed that small state influence materialises when credible delivery meets functioning institutions and “shelter”. In those circumstances, *ceteris paribus*¹, small states’ influence is maximised.

The mechanism is cumulative rather than singular. Niche specialisation opens doors once a credibility threshold is crossed. Organisational agility matters only when faster detection and coordination are coupled to decision forums that reward speed. Hybrid leverage magnifies reach when expertise is platformed through institutions and coalitions can absorb retaliation. Legitimacy, finally, functions as a conditional COG. It converts moral and just conduct into authority, where audiences and institutions recognise and facilitate it.

The Ireland–Gaza episode crystallises both promise and boundary. Dublin mobilised moral entrepreneurship and institutional channels, contributing to elements of consensus on humanitarian restraint. Decisive outcomes, however, rested with a superpower. There are potential opportunity costs as well. Strong moral signalling can narrow room for manoeuvre where key economic relationships are engaged. The lesson is not to retreat from normative diplomacy but to sequence it. To lead where delivery can be translated into text, posts and implementation. To calibrate positions in order to safeguard the base that sustains influence.

Boundary cases reinforce the conditionality claim. Israel (backed by alliance ties and superior capabilities) and the DPRK (protected by nuclear deterrence) demonstrate that security outcomes can be achieved with weak or contested legitimacy. They tend, however,

¹All other things being equal.

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to pay higher reputational and coalition costs. They also tend to register lower institutional influence, trading institutional influence for coercive autonomy . This confirms that legitimacy is not a standalone substitute for power. It is a social and political practice whose yield is mediated by institutional health and great-power consensus.

For policy seeking influence, the implication is pragmatic. An institution-first, delivery-backed strategy offers the most reliable route to durable influence. Small states should focus on fora where they hold drafting authority and penholdership. They should seek rapporteurships and contact-group roles. Coalition backing should come before promoting norms in contested areas. Success depends on turning access into adoption and maintaining that adoption through consistent delivery. Multipolarity appears resurgent. Ireland should recall the Proclamation and rely first on its own strength, part of which is the military. In a competitive order, this is how a small state turns performance into outcomes, while recognising that the last word in crisis diplomacy often belongs to great powers.

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Glossary of Terms

Constructivism (IR) Constructivism is a social theory that argues the main features of international politics are not fixed in advance but created through human interaction and shared practices. It sees states and structures as shaping each other and stresses that social and cultural contexts matter. It is not limited to one method of study. Recent developments such as practice theory and relationalism have broadened constructivism's focus. Instead of looking only at norms and identities, they highlight how everyday actions, relationships, and processes form the basis of world politics. This approach also helps overcome old divides, such as between agents and structures or ideas and material power (McCourt 2016).

English School (IR) A historically informed, normatively progressivist approach that treats world politics as a *society of states* organised by common institutions and norms. It explains movement from mere inter-state *system* toward *international society*. It distinguishes pluralist (order/coexistence) and solidarist (rights/protection) variants (Linklater and Suganami 2006, pp. 1-5).

Influence Influence is the deliberate shaping of actors' perceptions, decisions and behaviour to achieve political objectives. Small state influence is observed as shifts in mandates, allocations, coalition behaviour and delivery priorities, rather than control.

Intensity of Interest This is how much a state cares about a specific issue when compared with everything else on its plate. It is shown by what costs it will pay (money, risk, time, reputation) to get its way. The side that cares more (and shows it) often shapes the outcome, even if it is smaller (Bjøl 1968).

Legitimacy Legitimacy denotes the perception that a state's conduct is appropriate, credible and aligned with accepted norms and institutions (Clark 2005), leveraging soft power (Nye 2008).

Normative (English School use) In this context, ‘normative’ means giving prescriptive guidance for how states *ought* to act to uphold and improve the moral quality of international life. It is grounded in real trends and practical steps, not abstract theory alone (Linklater and Suganami 2006, pp. 9–11).

Performative Liberalism A construct of the author to describe leaders who sincerely believe in liberal values, yet must hedge or act within realist constraints, imposed by dependence on external shelters.

Pluralist Society of States A pluralist order is about coexistence and damage-limitation between sovereign states. Its rules (“international harm conventions”) aim to reduce inter-state harm (think non-aggression, territorial integrity and non-intervention). The priority is order among states, not enforcing shared values inside them (Linklater and Suganami 2006, p. 8).

Prestige Threshold The minimum an actor will do to keep their reputation and commitments intact (ally credibility, domestic promises, legal obligations) (Bjøl 1968).

Progressivist (English School use) The view that international society can *improve*, step by step, in protecting people and restraining war. It is cautious (not utopian). It looks for real and observable trends. It does not assume progress is automatic. It supports moving toward solidarist goals when conditions allow (Linklater and Suganami 2006, pp. 1, 9–10).

Provocation Threshold The maximum an actor will do before their actions unnecessarily provoke a stronger neighbour (Bjøl 1968).

Small State This essay defines a small state as one that lacks the material or diplomatic means to act unilaterally and must instead pursue influence through adaptation, perception and legitimacy within systems dominated by larger powers. This essay uses “small states” and “small powers” synonymously.

Solidarist Society of States A solidarist order is about protecting individuals across borders. Its rules (“cosmopolitan harm conventions”) aim to reduce harm to people,

even when they are citizens of other states. The priority is justice for individuals (human rights, protection from mass atrocities) and it can legitimate collective action that reaches inside states (Linklater and Suganami 2006, p. 8).

List of Acronyms

COG Centre of Gravity.

CSDP Common Security and Defence Policy.

DPRK Democratic People's Republic of Korea.

GDPR General Data Protection Regulation.

IR International Relations.

LIO Liberal International Order.

OTB Israeli Settlements in the Occupied Palestinian Territory (Prohibition of Importation of Goods) Bill.

SWIFT Society for Worldwide Interbank Financial Telecommunication.

UN United Nations.

UNSC United Nations Security Council.

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